

The Department of Defense and its Correspondence Relationship with Legislators

PS 699: Independent Study (Spring 2020)

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Introduction

Literature Review

Theory

Why is the DOD an Important Agency to Study?

Established in 1949, the Department of Defense's mission is "to provide the military forces needed to deter war and to protect the security of our country." The DOD is the oldest and government agency (dating back to the pre-revolutionary era) of the US federal government, and the agency employees over 2.8 million people, civilians, active duty military members, and National Guard/Reservists combined. The department is headed by the Secretary of Defense, who directly reports to the President, who is also the commander in chief of the military. There are three main branches in the military, the Army, Navy, and Air Force. Additionally, there are four national intelligence agencies, the Defense Intelligence Agency, the National Security Agency, the National Geospatial Intelligence Agency, and the National Reconnaissance Office. There are several other imperative DOD agencies that altogether serve the country and the 11 Unified combatant commands, that are located all around the world.

The DOD regularly makes decisions that have consequences both for Americans fighting in the armed services as well as civilians who are living in the US and abroad. DOD frequently regulates policies regarding national security and any policy matter related to the armed forces, specifically budget allotment within the three branches of the military as well as the Program Guidance Letter (PGL) which is an implementation plan that provides strategic level guidance to commanders and their directed initiatives.

As of March 3, 2020, the estimates US military spending in 934 billion dollars. This is the second largest item in the federal budget right after Social Security. There are several components to the budget, the first being the base budget which consists of 636 billion dollars. The second portion is for overseas operations, which accounts for 69 billion dollars. The third is allocated to other agencies which work hand in hand with the DOD. These agencies include the Department of Veteran Affairs, Department of Homeland Security, the State Department, the the National Nuclear Security Administration in the Department of Energy, and the FBI and Cybersecurity in the Department of Justice.

The DOD receives thousands of letters from congressmembers each year, especially regarding national security concerns, as well as due to concerns that happen while serving in the military (pay issues, sexual harrassment cases, and issues with the Chain of Command). Sexual harrassment cases and issues with military units are typically common cases that come to congressmembers, simply because it is usually difficult to bring these issues up to a superior in the military, and often times, writing to a legislator allows a service member to state their concerns without receiving backlash from their unit. Defense spending has been increasing exponentially, but many defense scholars believe that this is necessary, in order to ensure peace and stability for the United States. Mackenzie Eaglen, a resident fellow at the American Enterprise Institute stated that it is expensive to maintain peace amongst the US and other allies, but it is even more expensive to be involved in a long war, which is why it's important that legislators are cognizant on how the defense budget allocation is efficient, yet preventative.

Data and Data Collection

In order to to examine the relationship between the department of campaign contributions and letter-writing activity, the Correspondence project assemble a submitted over 400 Freedom of Information Act (FOIA) requests to all federal agencies in order to get records of communication from Members of Congress and their staff to all cabinet departments, their component agencies, and 34 independent agencies for the period from 2007-2018. I also went to some FOIA reading rooms and saved PDFs of letters that were written between congressmembers and DOD_OSDJS. In general, it is difficult to get actual letters from Federal Agencies, specifically the DOD, due to the fact that there is often sensitive information in these letters. Furthermore, many FOIA logs/letters have been recently removed from agency web pages due to the current administration's wish on regulating information that can be viewed by the public.

As of March 2020, the correspondence project has received data from DoD_DECA, DOD_DFAS, DLA_Aviation, DOD_USACE, DOD_Navy, DOD_OIG, DOD_OSDJS. We are still waiting on data from several other DOD agencies including by not limited to: Marine Corps, Air Force, Army, the Defense Intelligence Agency (DIA), and about 60 other subagencies. With the FOIA requests that we have received, I individually handcoded each letter by looking at the subject and determining which policy category it falls in. (1) is for personal/constituent service, (2) is commercial service-transactional, (3) is Government and Nonprofit Service, (4) is commercial service-policy, and (5) is for policy work. In the event that of not being able to figure out what type of policy the letter dealt with, I either research the topic/tried to find the letter via the FOIA reading logs or I left it as 0, which signifies as unknown. Example letters of each policy category will be added to an appendix in a later draft. One important item to note is that I considered foreign/defense strategic, foreign/defense crisis, and foreign/defense structural to fall under category 5. Congressmembers tend to influence foreign and defense policy based off of letters/concerns they receive due to international crisis and threats to national security, as well as concerns/suggestions regarding organization of military personnel and materiel, thus, I found that it was important to denote those types of letters inside category 5 (Lindsay et. al, 1994).

Altogether we have 7635 letters received by the Department of Defense that are marked as "congressional" from 2007-2017. All of these letters are from Members of the U.S. Congress. Note: During my independent study, I handcoded approximately 3,492 letters from a variety of Department of Defense agencies. Unfortunately, we were not able to implement these observations into the final data set. Thus, observations that are missing a Policy Type Category have a current Type of NA.

A Potential Outlier

In this analysis, Senator Grassley (R-IA) is considered to be an outlier. He wrote 188 letters to the Department of Defense, the most out of any other members of congress. However, he was never a part of any committee that actively work for the Department of Defense. Although at this point, we are unable to see what are the policy categories of the letters he wrote to the Department of Defense, based off of the hand-coding I did, Grassley wrote a majority of his letters on behalf of constituents, specifically for Veterans in Iowa. On further analysis, Grassley's campaign has largely been based on providing veterans in Iowa opportunities to present their legacy to other residents in Iowa and the US, and more within the realm of congressional agencies, aid with ensuring that veterans receive their benefits after retiring or being discharged from the military. These benefits include disability compensation, education programs, health benefits, and more. A majority of these concerns would be best addressed via the Department of Veteran Affairs versus most of the Department of Defense agencies, however, many of the issues, such as Military Pay complaints as well as sexual harrassment allegations can indeed be addressed with the Department of Defense agencies, such as the Department of Defense and Accounting Service (DFAS) as well as the Office of the Inspector General, U.S. Department of Defense (DOD_OIG). Thus, at this time, I am not considering Senator Grassley to be an outlier in my analysis.

Table 1: Top Policy Categories within Grassley’s Letters to the DOD

bioname	party	TYPE	cqlabel	n
GRASSLEY, Charles Ernest	(R)	NA	(IA)	168
GRASSLEY, Charles Ernest	(R)	1	(IA)	19
GRASSLEY, Charles Ernest	(R)	5	(IA)	1

Top 10 Legislators who wrote the most letters to the DOD

Except for Senator Grassley, many of the legislators who most frequently wrote letters to the DOD were either Veterans and/or members of the Armed Services committee or the Appropriations committee. At this moment, a majority of the letters written by the top legislators are letters written on behalf of constituents. As new observations are implemented, I expect constituent letters to still be the highest, but I expect policy/oversight letters as well as letters on behalf of businesses to slowly trickle in due to the logs we have from the DOD_USACE agency as well as the DOD_OIG/DOD_OSDJS agencies.

Table 2: Legislators who wrote the most letters to DOD

bioname	party	chamber	cqlabel	committees
GRASSLEY, Charles Ernest	(R)	Senate	(IA)	AGRICULTURE BUDGET FINANCE JUDICIARY TA
FORBES, J. Randy	(R)	House	(VA-04)	ARMED SERVICES JUDICIARY
McCAIN, John Sidney, III	(R)	Senate	(AZ)	ARMED SERVICES HOMELAND SECURITY INDIAN
NELSON, Clarence William (Bill)	(D)	Senate	(FL)	ARMED SERVICES COMMERCE FINANCE AGING
HUNTER, Duncan Duane	(R)	House	(CA-50)	ARMED SERVICES EDUCATION TRANSPORTATION
PELOSI, Nancy	(D)	House	(CA-08)	SPEAKER
McCASKILL, Claire	(D)	Senate	(MO)	ARMED SERVICES COMMERCE HOMELAND SECUR
OBEY, David Ross	(D)	House	(WI-07)	APPROPRIATIONS
WOLF, Frank Rudolph	(R)	House	(VA-10)	APPROPRIATIONS
WITTMAN, Robert J.	(R)	House	(VA-01)	ARMED SERVICES NATURAL RESOURCES

Table 3: Policy Categories within Legislators’ Letters to the DOD

bioname	party	chamber	TYPE	cqlabel	committees
GRASSLEY, Charles Ernest	(R)	Senate	NA	(IA)	AGRICULTURE BUDGET FINANCE JUDICIARY
FORBES, J. Randy	(R)	House	NA	(VA-04)	ARMED SERVICES JUDICIARY
WEBB, James H. (Jim)	(D)	Senate	NA	(VA)	ARMED SERVICES FOREIGN RELATIONS
McCASKILL, Claire	(D)	Senate	NA	(MO)	ARMED SERVICES COMMERCE HOMELAND SECURITY
NELSON, Clarence William (Bill)	(D)	Senate	1	(FL)	ARMED SERVICES COMMERCE FINANCE
PELOSI, Nancy	(D)	House	6	(CA-08)	SPEAKER
BOOZMAN, John	(R)	Senate	1	(AR)	AGRICULTURE APPROPRIATIONS ENVIRONMENT
OBEY, David Ross	(D)	House	6	(WI-07)	APPROPRIATIONS
TOOMEY, Patrick Joseph	(R)	Senate	1	(PA)	BANKING BUDGET FINANCE
GRAHAM, Lindsey O.	(R)	Senate	1	(SC)	APPROPRIATIONS ARMED SERVICES BUDGET
WOLF, Frank Rudolph	(R)	House	1	(VA-10)	APPROPRIATIONS

Table 4: Most Common Policy Areas

TYPE	n
1	3798
5	149
6	88
0	43
2	35
3	25
4	3

114th Congress

According to the diagram below, currently, our data set shows that a majority of letters have been written on behalf of constituent issues. However, the 114th congress has 3722 letters. This the most amount of letters received by the DOD during a congressional term. One reason why this result may be showing at the moment is because a majority of the logs we have received from the DOD are from the 114th congress (January 2015-January 2017). Another reason why there is a large influx of letters from the 114th congress is because there were numerous scandals that were unraveled, mainly scandals regarding sexual assault and deficiencies with veterans receiving theirn health and discharge records. The tables below show that a majority of letters were written to the DOD with issues during the constituent's time in service, mainly issues that have the subject lines of pay during their enlistment or the process of being discharged and collecting their records afterwards.

Warning: position_dodge requires non-overlapping x intervals

Policy Category Counts amongst chambers and Congressional Years

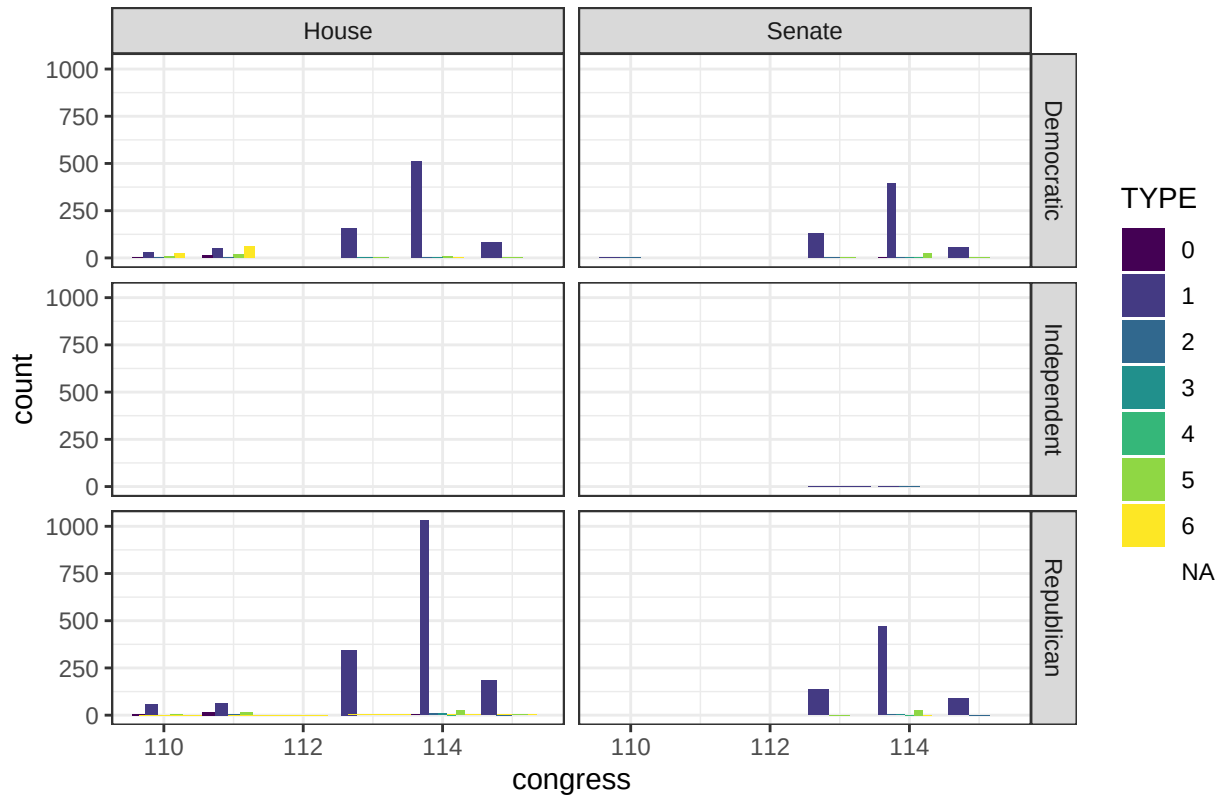


Table 5: Letters from Each Congressional session

congress	n
114	3722
113	1384
111	704
115	700
110	682
112	443

Table 6: Top 10 Legislators who wrote letters in 114th Congress

bioname	party	cqlabel	committees
McCAIN, John Sidney, III	(R)	(AZ)	ARMED SERVICES HOMELAND SECURITY INDIAN
NELSON, Clarence William (Bill)	(D)	(FL)	ARMED SERVICES COMMERCE FINANCE AGING
GRASSLEY, Charles Ernest	(R)	(IA)	AGRICULTURE BUDGET FINANCE JUDICIARY TAXATION
HUNTER, Duncan Duane	(R)	(CA-50)	ARMED SERVICES EDUCATION TRANSPORTATION
BOOZMAN, John	(R)	(AR)	AGRICULTURE APPROPRIATIONS ENVIRONMENT RULES V
BURR, Richard M.	(R)	(NC)	FINANCE HEALTH INTELLIGENCE
TOOMEY, Patrick Joseph	(R)	(PA)	BANKING BUDGET FINANCE
FORBES, J. Randy	(R)	(VA-04)	ARMED SERVICES JUDICIARY
MURRAY, Patty	(D)	(WA)	APPROPRIATIONS BUDGET HEALTH VETERANS
RUBIO, Marco	(R)	(FL)	COMMERCE FOREIGN RELATIONS SMALL BUSINESS INTEL

Table 7: Top 10 Subjects of Letters sent to DOD in 114th Congress

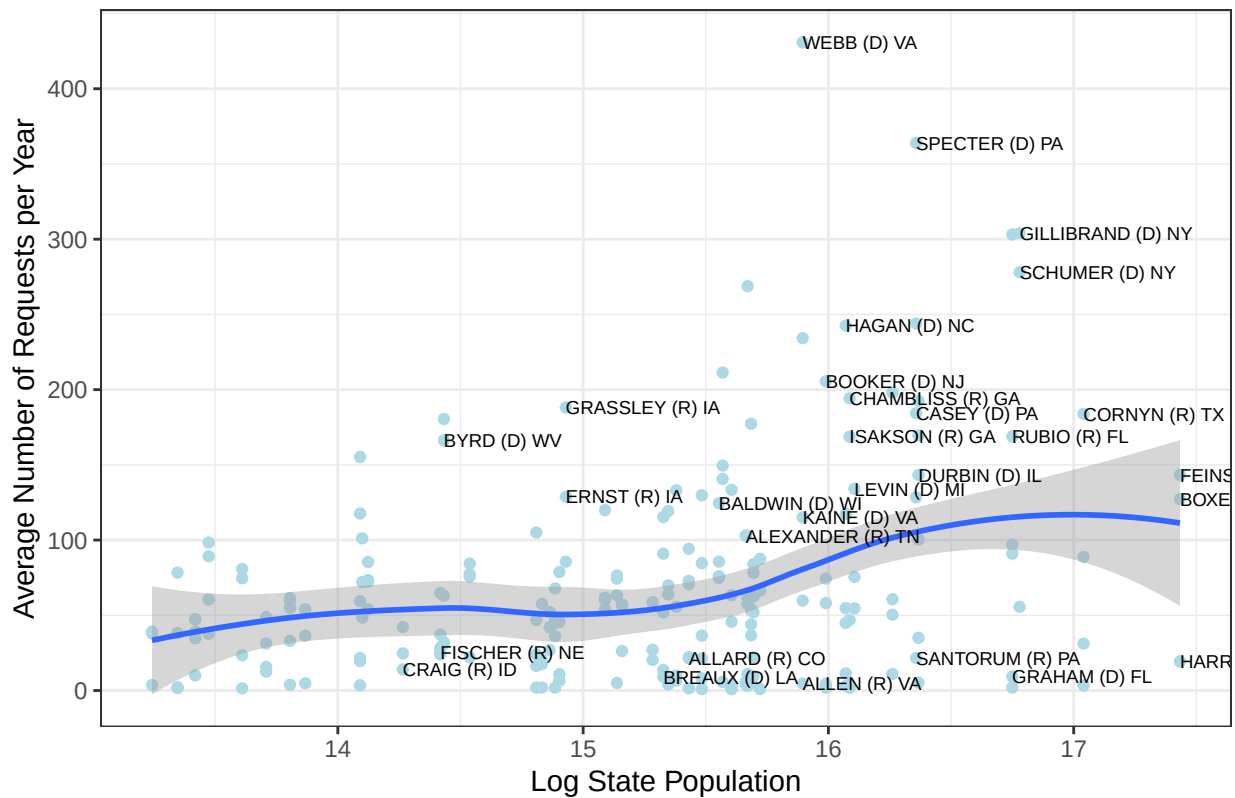
SUBJECT	agency	n
#NAME?	DOD_Navy	322
MILITARY PAY - ARMY, AIRFORCE	DOD_DFAS	191
NA	DOD_OIG	134
- REQUEST FOR UPGRADE OF DISCHARGE -	DOD_Navy	45
- DESIRE TO ENLIST -	DOD_Navy	44
- REQUEST FOR CORRECTION OF RECORDS -	DOD_Navy	34
- DISCHARGE UPGRADE REQUEST -	DOD_Navy	27
8 SENATORS CONCERNED ABOUT THE CONVERSION OF DeCA EMPLOYEES	DOD_DeCA	27
- REQUEST TO ENLIST INTO THE NAVY -	DOD_Navy	26
- EMPLOYMENT CONCERNS -	DOD_Navy	24

Letter Writing Driven by State and Veteran Population

a) Letters to All Agencies

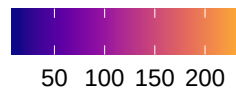
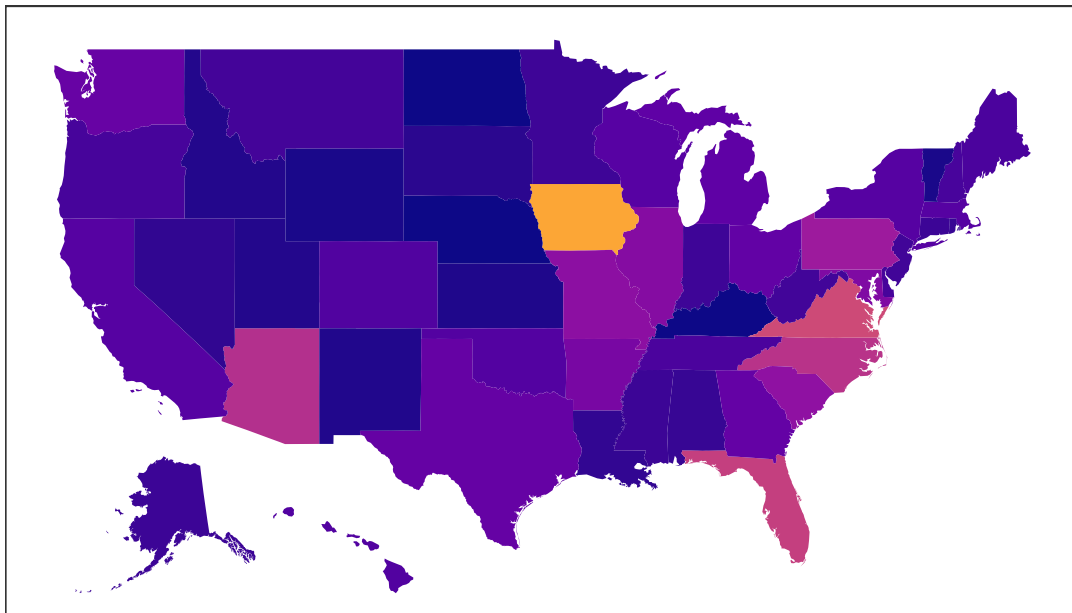
```
## `geom_smooth()` using method = 'loess' and formula 'y ~ x'
```

Senator Requests per Year for all Agencies by State Population



b) Letters Written to the DOD

Total Number of Contacts from members of the Senate

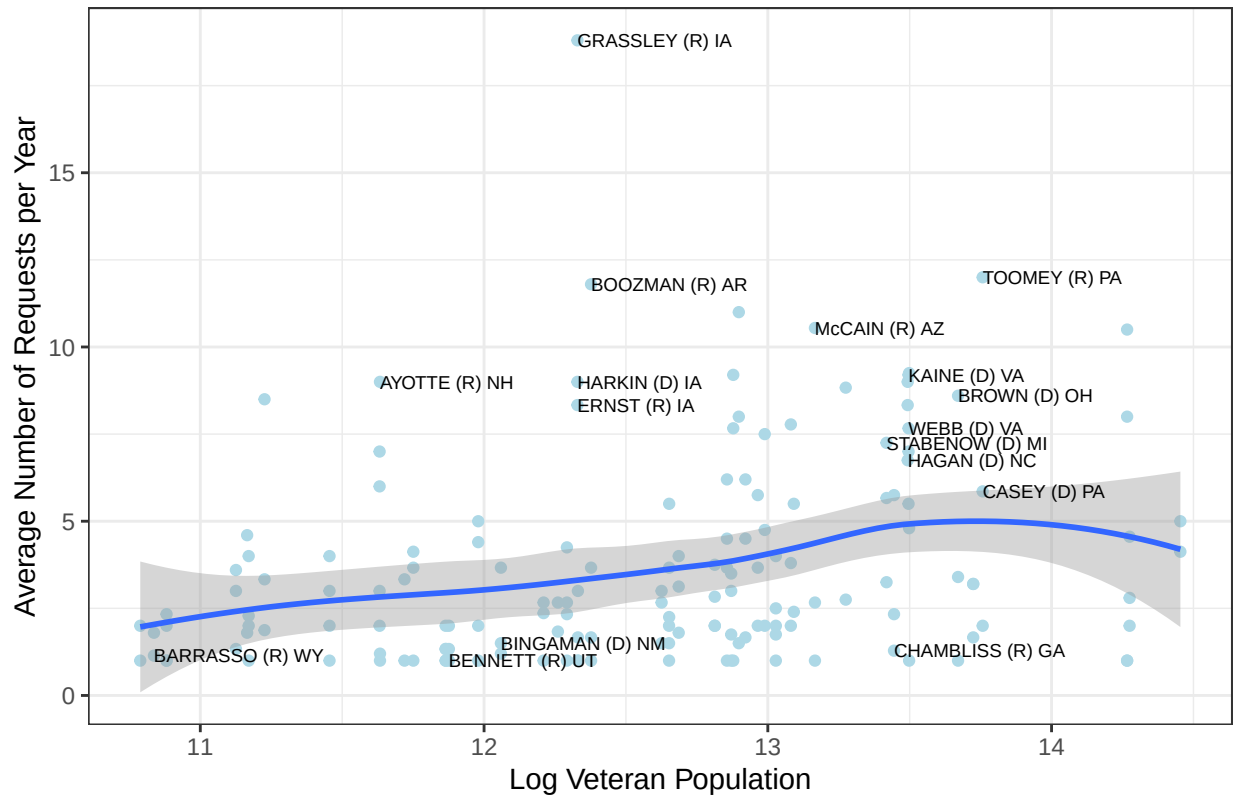


A choropleth map of the United States showing the percentage of the population aged 18 and over who are married. The map uses a color scale from dark purple (low percentage) to bright orange (high percentage). The highest percentages are concentrated in the Midwest, particularly in Illinois, Indiana, and Michigan, which are colored bright orange. Other states with high percentages include Ohio, Pennsylvania, and New York. The majority of states are colored in shades of purple and blue, indicating lower percentages. The map also includes Alaska and Hawaii.

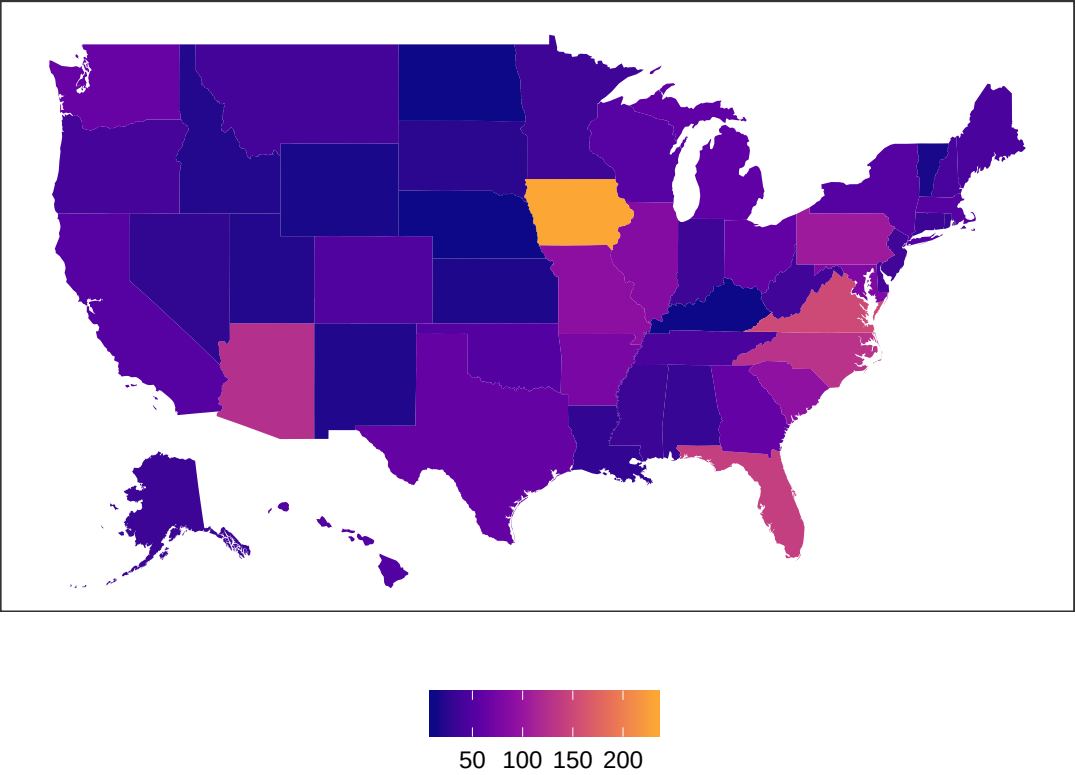
```
## Joining, by = "state"

## `geom_smooth()` using method = 'loess' and formula 'y ~ x'
```

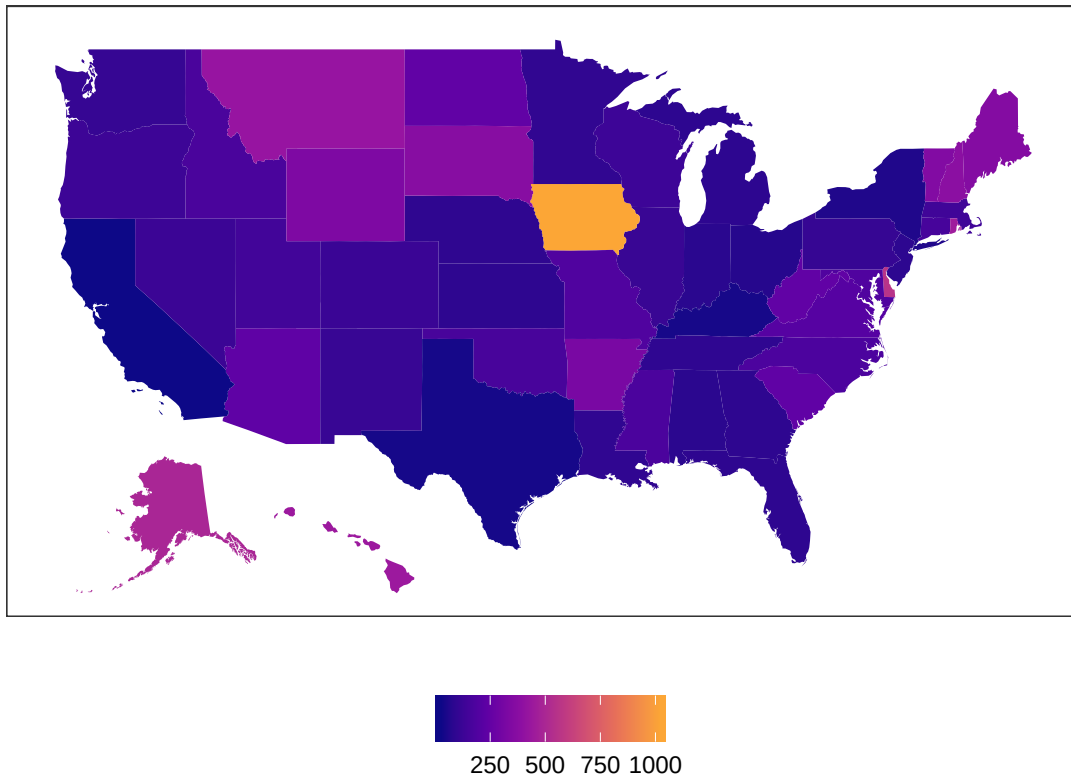
Senator Requests per Year by Veteran Population



Contacts from members of the Senate per Veteran Population in State



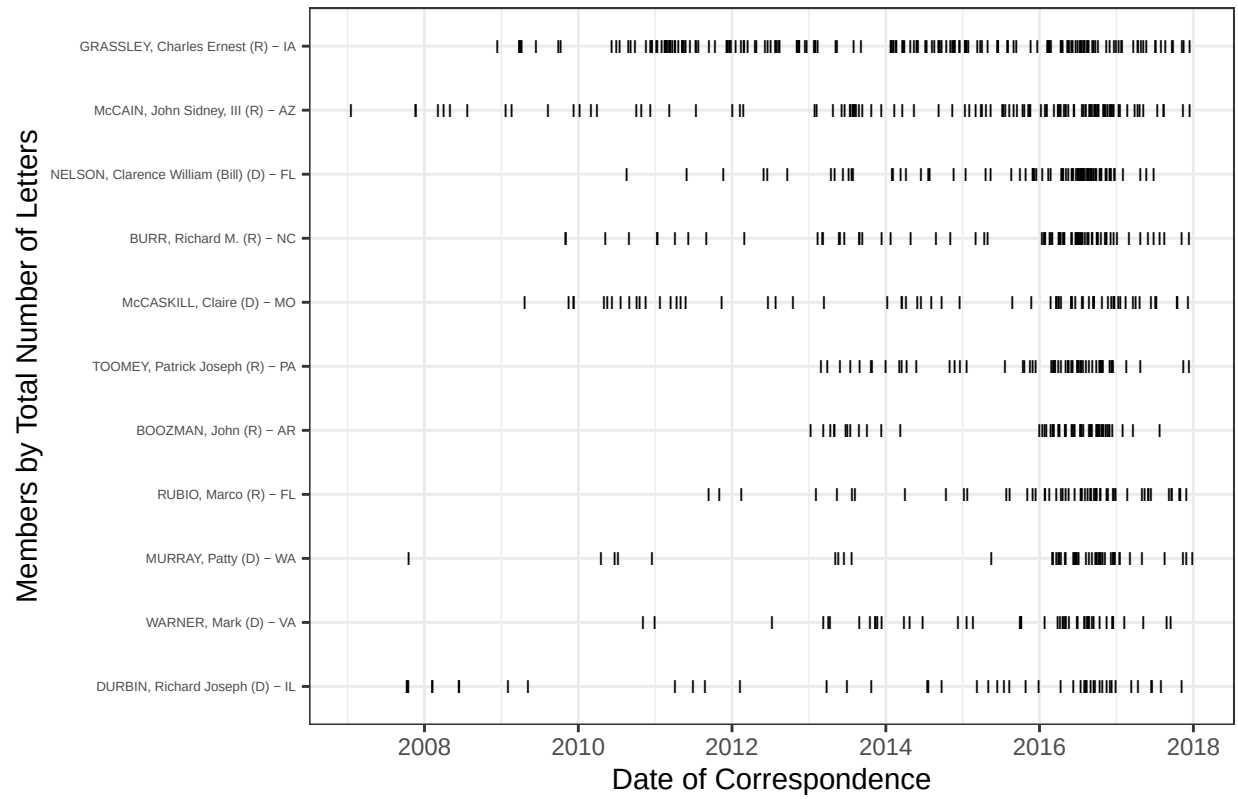
Contacts Per Million Veteran Residents from Members of the Senate

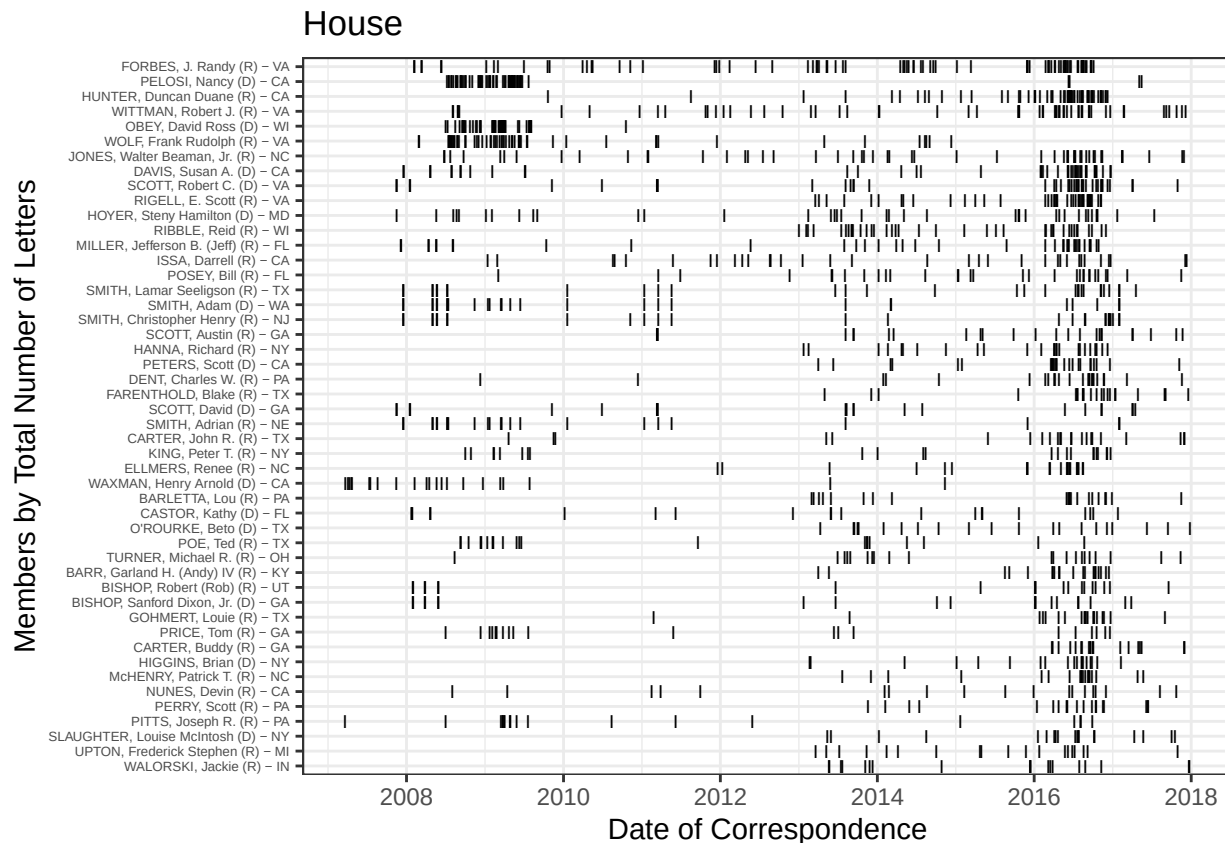


Members who contact DOD more than average

The following panels show members of congress who contact the DOD more than average. The top panel shows the Senators who wrote the most letters to the DOD and the bottom panel shows the Representatives who wrote the most letters to the DOD. The hash mark represents the legislator that wrote a letter on that date. It is important to note that many members listed in the table weren't in the chamber for the entire period, so blank stretches at the end or beginning of the line may possibly indicate that the member of congress was out of office during that time period. Note that Chuck Grassley wrote the most letters to the DOD amongst all members of the Senate. It is also important to note that there was a large increase in letters written to congress from 2016-2018. This is mainly due to the fact that there were a huge amount of scandals that were discovered within the DOD, especially regarding military pay and the treatment of civilians and soldiers in hospitals in Afghanistan.

Senate

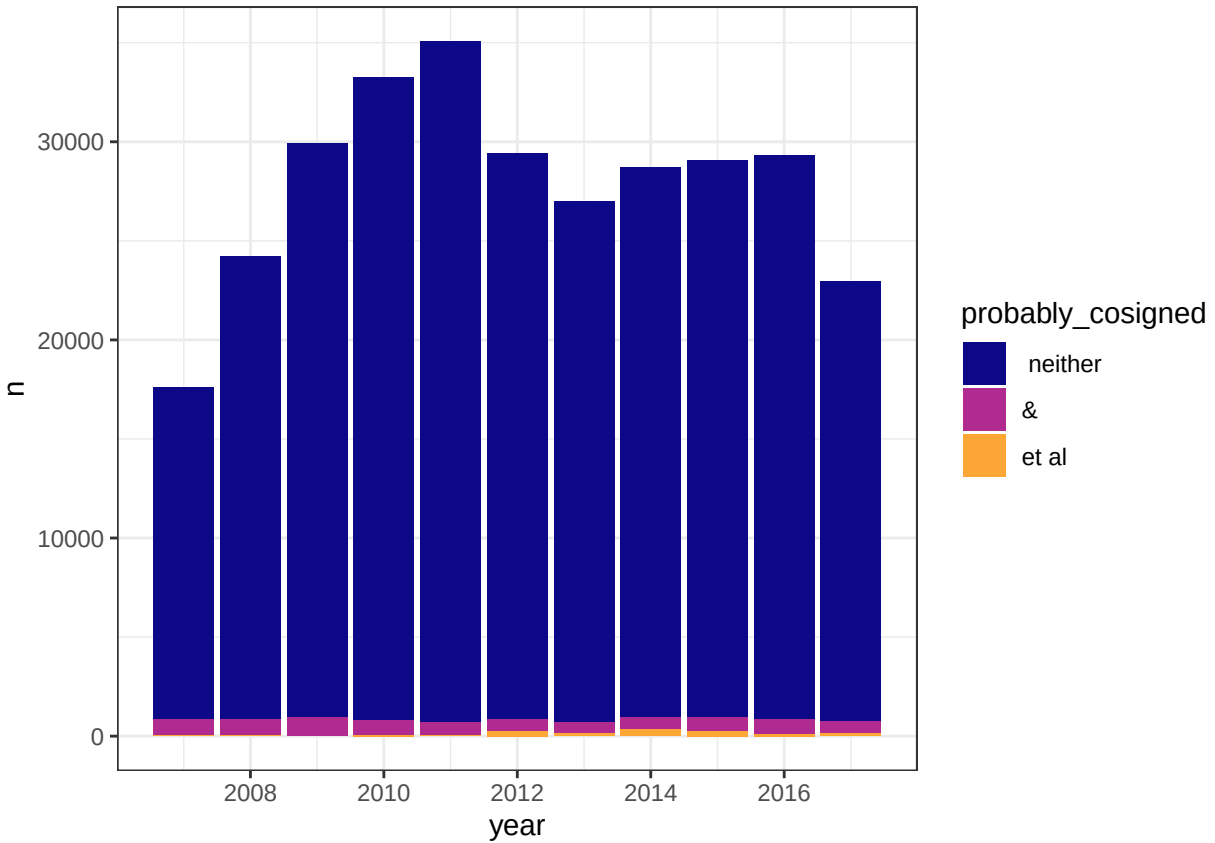




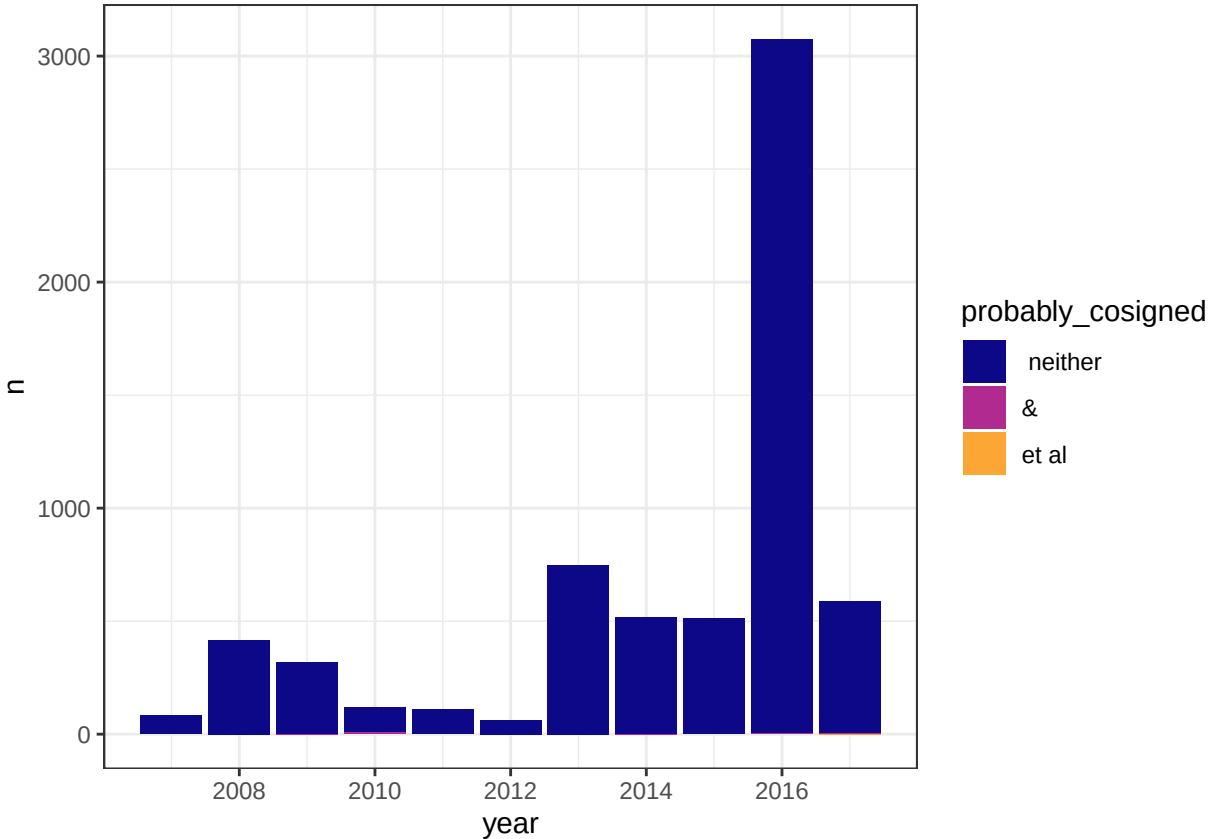
Are letters to the DOD Cosigned?

This section shows a rough under-estimate based off of whether “et al” or “&” appears in the summary.

The first figure shows the amount of letters that are cosigned in all the federal agencies that we currently have data for. There aren’t many letters that are cosigned, but there are still a notable amount in all years.



In contrast, the DOD has a very miniscule amount of letters that are cosigned. This is shown in 2010. It was surprising to see the lack of letters to the DOD that were cosigned, but this is indeed a rough estimate, and I suspect that as more observations are implemented, there will be a greater amount of letters that are shown to be cosigned. Letters that are cosigned could show a variety items, whether it's partnership on rule-making between party members or even bipartisan-styled letters between members of a different party who are working in the same committee.



Top Female Legislators who wrote the most letters to the DOD

The following charts show the top female legislators who wrote to the DOD both in general and by committees that are relevant to the DOD such as the armed services, veterans, foreign relations, and appropriations committees. Many of the women who frequently write letters to the DOD represent states that are home to a large veteran population. However, I was surprised at the few amount of letters that were written by female veterans to the DOD. For instance, I expected to see Joni Ernst (R-IA) or Martha McSally (R-AZ) on the list, but they only wrote 24 letters to the DOD.

Further investigation shows that as of 2019, there are four female veterans serving in the House of Representatives-this is considered to be a record high. This inspired representatives Mikie Sherril, Tulsi Gabbard, Elaine Luria, and Chrissy Houlahan to create the House Servicewomen and Women Veterans Congressional Caucus. Curenly, there are three female veterans in the senate, Senators Tami Duckworth, Joni Ernst and Martha McSally. I anticipate that as more observations are implemented, especially from 2019, that I will be able to get a better grasp on the influence that female veterans have in the DOD.

Table 8: Female Legislators who wrote the most letters to DOD

bioname	party	chamber	cqlabel	committees
PELOSI, Nancy	(D)	House	(CA-08)	SPEAKER
DAVIS, Susan A.	(D)	House	(CA-53)	ARMED SERVICES EDUCATION
PELOSI, Nancy	(D)	House	(CA-08)	SPEAKER
BALDWIN, Tammy	(D)	Senate	(WI)	APPROPRIATIONS BUDGET HOMELAND SECURITY
ELLMERS, Renee	(R)	House	(NC-02)	ENERGY

bioname	party	chamber	cqlabel	committees
HIRONO, Mazie	(D)	Senate	(HI)	ARMED SERVICES ENERGY SMALL BUSINESS VETERANS
BROWNLEY, Julia	(D)	House	(CA-26)	TRANSPORTATION VETERANS
TITUS, Alice (Dina)	(D)	House	(NV-01)	TRANSPORTATION VETERANS
EDWARDS, Donna F.	(D)	House	(MD-04)	TRANSPORTATION SCIENCE
ADAMS, Alma	(D)	House	(NC-12)	AGRICULTURE ECONOMIC EDUCATION SMALL BUSINESS
GILLIBRAND, Kirsten	(D)	Senate	(NY)	AGRICULTURE ARMED SERVICES ENVIRONMENT NATURAL RESOURCES
SLAUGHTER, Louise McIntosh	(D)	House	(NY-25)	RULES

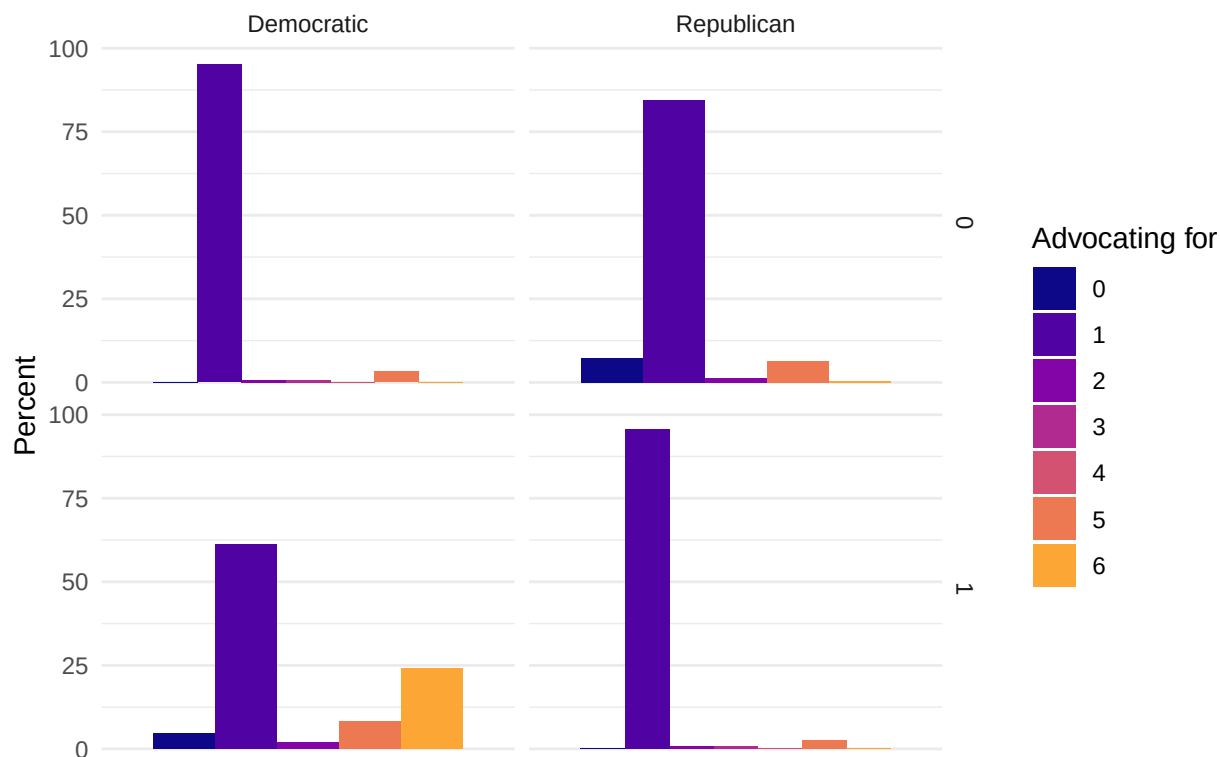
Table 9: Female Relevant Committee Members who wrote the most letters to DOD according

bioname	party	chamber	cqlabel	committees
DAVIS, Susan A.	(D)	House	(CA-53)	ARMED SERVICES EDUCATION
BALDWIN, Tammy	(D)	Senate	(WI)	APPROPRIATIONS BUDGET HOMELAND SECURITY INTELLIGENCE
HIRONO, Mazie	(D)	Senate	(HI)	ARMED SERVICES ENERGY SMALL BUSINESS VETERANS
BROWNLEY, Julia	(D)	House	(CA-26)	TRANSPORTATION VETERANS
TITUS, Alice (Dina)	(D)	House	(NV-01)	TRANSPORTATION VETERANS
GILLIBRAND, Kirsten	(D)	Senate	(NY)	AGRICULTURE ARMED SERVICES ENVIRONMENT NATURAL RESOURCES
HERRERA BEUTLER, Jaime	(R)	House	(WA-03)	APPROPRIATIONS
DAVIS, Susan A.	(D)	House	(CA-53)	ARMED SERVICES EDUCATION HOUSE ADMINISTRATION
HARTZLER, Vicky	(R)	House	(MO-04)	AGRICULTURE ARMED SERVICES
WALORSKI, Jackie	(R)	House	(IN-02)	AGRICULTURE ARMED SERVICES VETERANS

Note: There are duplicates with members in these charts that will be removed/condensed in another draft.

By Party

This figure represented the letters written to the DOD that members of different parties wrote while they were in the majority/minority. The upper left panel shows the letters to FERC that were written by democrat while they were in the majority, as well as what was the percentage they were advocating for on behalf of the different policy categories. The lower left panel represents the Democrats while they were in the minority. The upper right and lower right show the the same proportions for the Republican party while they were in the majority and minority respectively. For the most part, Democrats and Republicans tend to advocate the most for constituents regardless of whether they are in the majority or minority. However, Democrats tend to write regarding rule-making, oversight, and municipalities/states, especially when they are in the minority. Republicans on the other hand, tend to write slightly less letters on behalf of constituents when they are in the majority, but write quite a few more letters on behalf of constituents when they are in the minority, in respect to their democratic counterparts.



Bivariate and Multivariate Models

To be created.

In this draft of the paper, I did not create any variate models, mainly because I was missing a lot of data points for areas that I wanted to look into. In the future, I hope to create models that show the relationship between gender and letters written, non-constituent and constituent letters written in the DOD, as well as the contrast of political parties in the collection of letters that the DOD receives. Exploring these pieces may help with looking more closely into which party advocates more for constituents/businesses in the DOD, which party writes to the DOD in general, as well as if there is any gender bias when it comes to constituents who write letters to their congressman, especially if the congressman is a veteran and female.

Summary

Limitations throughout the Independent Study

Throughout the course of this independent study, there were a few limitations I faced. First of all, Google has increased their security as of November 2019, which means we no longer have access to many of the googlesheets packages we use in order to pull in data and organize it in an appropriate manner. Consequently, this means that a large majority of our data and observations have not been updated or accounted for in

the last 6 months. Thus, the thousands of letters that I handcoded, as well as the the dates that I had fixed within the DOD dataset were not able to be used in this first draft of the paper. Furthermore, we are still waiting to receive logs from several DOD agencies which would further allow my analysis to be complete. Many of the agencies I handcoded primarily were agencies that deal with civilians or veterans and I predict that as we receive logs from the Air Force and the Defense Logistics agency, we may see more interesting cases regarding the relationship between businesses and the DOD. Lastly, a lot of my analysis is still yet to be done, since I had issues with pieces of code not working as well as identifying characteristics (for instance, gender) missing with some members of congress. There are also some duplicates in the data set that I am working on fixing/evaluating as to why they are showing up.

Future ideas to explore with this paper

In the future, I hope to continue my exploration with this topic by analyzing some different aspects to help evaluate the overlying question of how Department of Defense agencies interact with constituents and legislators. One major category I'd like to investigate is demographics, both within members of congress as well as within constituents who write to their congressman. I am interested in exploring how a congressman's veteran status can influence their constituent relationship. Specifically, I am interested in seeing how gender, specifically a female veteran congressman can influence the bills that she introduces in congress as well as the types of policies that she may support as a result of her Active Duty experience or experience from dealing with veteran/active duty constituents. A method that can allow me to also investigate the demographic relationship with the DOD is by doing constituent coding as well as looking closely at the different congressional districts in the US, specifically the districts that have military bases or a large active duty/population. Moreover, I am interested in looking at bipartisan relationships within legislators who actively work with the DOD as well as take a further look at the policies and bills that are implemented within the different policy committees within the house and the senate. I am interested in looking into members who contact the DOD more, relative to other agencies as well and potentially what the reasoning may be behind that. Lastly, I am also curious about the relationship between legislators and businesses and I'm curious to see if in the future I can investigate certain companies that write to congressmembers and what their motive is behind the correspondence. An appendix, with extra figures, letters, and a FOIA request will also be added in a future draft of this paper.

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